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reviews

09.05.00 :: GEAR :: SAMSUNG EXTIVA ENHANCED DVD PLAYER

For most home-movie watchers, just getting a new DVD player hooked up and working would be a thrill. And then there are the gadget freaks -- the types who want to have smell-o-vision embedded in their brains as soon as humanly possible. Samsung's new Extiva Enhanced DVD Player doesn't usher in any new era of gadgetry, but it does go beyond simple DVD; it plays games, changes the look and feel of movies on-screen and even plays audio CDs in a whole new way.

As a standard DVD player, the unit performs admirably. The Extiva is easy to set up, with clear playback and great sound thanks to the Nuon processor, which allows the unit to process the data faster and better than non-enhanced units. Letterbox-formatted movies (a.k.a. widescreen ones) no longer pose a threat to smaller-screened televisions, as the Extiva allows you to display these films in their original wide orientation on standard screen sizes. Even better, you don't have to stop the movie to use the on-screen menus, so you can move through a scene with a smooth, controlled fast-forward or rewind.

The main reason that the Extiva stands out is because of its "extras." First, it plays a variety of 3D games on CD-ROM. Most of these games -- produced by Samsung along with select partners -- are family-oriented, such as a "Breakout" clone that comes with the unit and Monopoly (available soon). And it comes with a controller, similar to those found on home gaming systems, so you can instantly start playing these games. As an added bonus, the Extiva also plays audio CDs with a graphical display that shows a simple light show; on Nuon "enhanced" CDs (available from major record labels), you can watch animations, read lyrics or enjoy a host of other eye-candy.

If it were up to us, we'd add more games, downplay the visualized audio and drop the price. More serious gamers, audiophiles and movie lovers will soon graduate from here up to the big boys -- but home theater systems get pricey real fast. For the guy with limited space (dorms, small apartments) and generalized needs, this does a few new tricks quite nicely.

--Mike Talon



SAMSUNG EXTIVA ENHANCED DVD PLAYER

$399
www.samsung.com

TARGET AUDIENCE:
Technophiles who love movies

PROS:
Plays standard and "Nuon enhanced" DVDs, audio CDs and some games

CONS:
Costs about twice as much as a normal DVD player; supports only a limited number of games

Previously in Gear: GO

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